

Royal Letter of Joan I to a Bishop, on Behalf of Guillem Ribes of Perpinyà

Barcelona, 21 May 1387

Document summary

Field	Value
Archive	Arxiu de la Corona d'Aragó (ACA)
Series	Cancillería, registres
Folio	f. 146r (working identification)
Date	21 May 1387
Place of issue	Barcelona
Language	Catalan
Hand	Gothic secretarial (<i>lletra bastarda</i>), competent and slightly hurried
Document type	<i>Lletra closa</i> (royal intercession on behalf of a household member)
Sender	Joan I of Aragon (implicit; speaks in 1st person plural)
Addressee	An unnamed bishop (probably the bishop of Elna — see note 1)
Subject	Royal protest against the bishop's imprisonment of a royal <i>domèstech</i> , and order to render justice "in the said matter and nothing else"
Iussio / sign-off	Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor
Related corpus	Falls within the May 1387 Perpinyà-related cluster; cf. <i>ACA_JoanI_PiratePich_Perpinya_1387-05-08</i>

Reconciled transcription

· Bisbe, entes hauem q[ue] vos tenits pres en G[uille]m Ribes de Perpinya,

lo qual es domestech[?] n[ost]re, e al qual diem q[ue] ffets enantament contra ell, mas p[er] ynstigacio d'alcuns qui li porten ynimjztat q[ue] no per justicia, de la qual cosa, se vera es, nos marauellam molt, p[er]q[ue] vos diem e manam q[ue] en lo dit fet ffaçats justicia e no als. Certificant vos q[ue] si lo contrari ffariets, co q[ue] no creem, ffariets cosa dezonest a nos desplaent, majorment co lo dit G. sia n[ost]re domestech[?] segons dit es / Dada en Barch[ino]na[?] a .xxj. dia de maig de l'any de la nativitat de n[ost]re S[en]yor M.ccc.lxxx.vij. — Ff[ranciscus] ça Costa.

English translation

Bishop,¹ we have understood that you hold imprisoned Sir Guillem Ribes of Perpinyà,² who is our *domèstech*,³ and against whom — so we say to you — you are conducting proceedings,⁴ but at the instigation of certain persons who bear enmity toward him rather than out of justice. Of which matter, if it be true,⁵ we marvel greatly,⁶ for which reason we say and order you that in the said matter you render justice and nothing else.⁷ Certifying to you that, should you do the contrary — which we do not believe — you would do a dishonest thing,⁸ displeasing to us, all the more since the said G. is our *domèstech*, as has been said.

Given in Barcelona on the twenty-first day of May, in the year of the nativity of Our Lord 1387.⁹

Francesc ça Costa.¹⁰

Footnotes

Unresolved ambiguities

1. **Identification of the addressee bishop.** The letter names no see. The bishop of Elna is the most plausible recipient on grounds of jurisdiction over a Perpinyà resident, but the episcopal succession in 1387 is contested between Ramon d'Escales (whose tenure ended c. 1380) and Bartomeu Peiró (whose tenure conventionally begins in 1387). Verification against the Elna diocesan series and against any contemporaneous *vidit* notations elsewhere in the register may resolve whether Peiró was already in office on 21 May 1387, or whether the see was vacant and the letter was addressed to an episcopal *vicarius* or another bishop entirely.
2. **Identification of Guillem Ribes.** No independent attestation has been found in published reference works. The Perpinyà notarial archive and the *Llibre Verd Major* should be searched; the royal household lists in the *Real Patrimonio* registers may also yield him as a *domèstech*.

3. **Orthographic uncertainty: *domestech* vs *domestich*.** Both forms occur in medieval Catalan, and the terminal vowel in this hand is ambiguous in both of its occurrences on the folio. I have preserved *domestech* in the transcription, but the alternative cannot be excluded.
 4. **Orthographic uncertainty: *Barchinona* vs *Barchelona*.** Both are attested medieval forms. The chancery Latin standard is *Barchinona*, and I have preserved that reading, but on this folio the form is compressed by abbreviation and is not paleographically secure.
 5. **Place of imprisonment.** The text does not specify *where* Ribes is being held. The natural inference is somewhere in the diocese of Elna (most plausibly Perpinyà itself, where the bishop's effective residence was), but this is not stated.
 6. **The nature of the original proceeding.** The letter is silent on the alleged offense for which Ribes was imprisoned. This is normal in *lletres closes* of intercession — the king is asserting jurisdiction, not adjudicating the case — but it means the document on its own cannot be used to characterize the substance of the dispute, only its jurisdictional shape.
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Note for the dissertation argument

The document is a small but exemplary case of royal jurisdictional reach into episcopal proceedings on behalf of household members — a pattern that is recurring across the corpus. Three features are particularly worth retaining:

- The legal vocabulary is precise (*enantament*, *justicia*, *e no als*) rather than rhetorical: the king is not merely expressing displeasure but operating a jurisdictional claim.
 - The *domèstech* category is invoked as the explicit and sufficient ground for the intervention, which fits the household-vs-territorial-jurisdiction tension at the center of the dissertation's chancery-routing argument.
 - The sign-off by **Francesc ça Costa** as vice-chancellor confirms that this kind of intercession was routed through the highest chancery level rather than treated as routine correspondence — a point that may be worth tabulating against the *iussio* attributions of other intercession letters in the corpus.
1. **The addressee.** The letter names no diocese, but the prisoner's Perpinyà connection makes the bishop of Elna the most natural candidate: by the late fourteenth century the Elna bishops had effectively transferred their residence to Perpinyà (where they retained jurisdiction over the parish of Sant Joan), even though the cathedral seat remained nominally at Elna until 1601. The dating of this letter — 21 May 1387 — falls in a transitional moment in the see's chronology. Ramon d'Escales (bishop 1377–1380) had departed for the see of Barcelona; Bartomeu Peiró is conventionally dated from 1387, with the precise terminus a quo of his Elna episcopate not always clearly fixed in the standard lists. It is possible, then, that the letter is addressed to Peiró in the first weeks of his rule, but this

would warrant verification against the diocesan series. A second possibility — that the bishop is from another diocese in whose territory Ribes was caught — cannot be excluded on the surface of the text alone, since the prisoner's *de Perpinyà* identifies his origin, not necessarily the place of his imprisonment. ↵

2. **Guillem Ribes of Perpinyà.** I have not been able to identify this man independently of the present document. The corpus contains a number of figures associated with Perpinyà in the spring of 1387 (cf. the *pirata* Pich correspondence of 8 May), but no Guillem Ribes among them. He should be sought in the Perpinyà notarial series and the *Llibre Verd Major*, as well as in Joan I's *Real Patrimony* registers under the rubric of *domèstechs* and household officers. The Ribes surname is common in Rosselló and the dioceses of Elna and Barcelona alike; without a patronymic, occupation, or office, secure identification on present evidence is unattainable. Flag for prosopographical follow-up. ↵
3. **Domèstech.** The Catalan *domèstech* (Lat. *domesticus*) does not denote a "servant" in the modern menial sense; in fourteenth-century Aragonese chancery usage it refers to a member of the royal household — a category that could include scribes, chamber officers, falconers, physicians, musicians, and a wide range of dependents in personal proximity to the king. The status carried a substantive jurisdictional privilege: members of the king's household were ordinarily exempt from ordinary territorial and episcopal courts, justiciable instead before the royal court of the *cort* or a delegate of the king. The phrase *lo qual es domèstech nostre* is thus not incidental flavor but the legal foundation of the letter's grievance: by imprisoning Ribes, the bishop has overstepped his jurisdiction. ↵
4. **Enantament.** The Catalan technical noun *enantament* (from *enantar*, to proceed in a legal matter) denotes a formal step in judicial procedure — not merely an action against the prisoner, but an instituted process. The king's complaint is that the bishop has not simply detained Ribes but has initiated proceedings; the HTR's alternative reading *fo serenament* is gibberish and should be rejected. ↵
5. **Se vera es.** This hedge — "if it be true" — is rhetorically important: the king is professing not to have verified the report personally and thus leaves the bishop a face-saving exit, while in the same breath ordering him to render justice as if the report were true. The construction is standard in fourteenth-century Catalan royal correspondence where the king conveys information he has received second-hand and wishes to apply pressure without yet committing himself. ↵
6. **Nos marauellam.** The first-person plural reflexive *nos marauellam* ("we marvel," in the sense of being astonished or scandalized) is sharper in chancery register than its modern English translation suggests. It is the standard formula for expressing royal displeasure short of open rebuke. ↵
7. **E no als.** Literally "and nothing else" — but the phrase here is doing real jurisdictional work. The king is not merely ordering the bishop to render justice; he is restricting the bishop's procedural latitude. *Faceu justícia, e no als* signals that any outcome short of releasing Ribes (or proceeding only on legitimate grounds) will be treated as failure. The phrase is a

recurring marker in Joan I's interventions in ecclesiastical jurisdiction over royal dependents. ↵

8. **Cosa *dezonesta*.** *Deshonesta* (here spelled *dezonesta*, with the regular medieval Catalan -z- for -sh-) is not simply "dishonest" in the modern moral sense; in this context it carries the older sense of *inhonestus* — "improper, unbecoming, contrary to the proper order of things." When the king characterizes a bishop's continued imprisonment of a royal household member as *cosa dezonesta a nos desplaent*, he is grading the act on a scale of jurisdictional propriety more than of moral honesty. ↵
9. **Dating.** *Dada en Barchinona a xxj dia de maig de l'any de la nativitat de nostre Senyor M ccc lxxx vij* = "given at Barcelona on 21 May 1387." Joan I had acceded on 5 January 1387, so this letter falls in the king's fourth full month of rule. The Barcelona itinerary is consistent with the king's known movements in the spring of 1387, and the date sits within the same Perpinyà-related cluster of correspondence as the 8 May *pirata* Pich document already in the corpus. ↵
10. **Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor.** The *iussio* is signed by **Francesc ça Costa**, vice-chancellor of the Crown of Aragon under Joan I. His sign-off on a letter of this type — a *lletra closa* asserting royal jurisdiction over a household member against an episcopal court — places the document within the highest tier of chancery business. *Ça Costa* (with the medieval Catalan reduced article *ça*, from *ipsa*) is the family name; the *iussio* gives no further title. The HTR's reading *coftus* reflects the long-s of *costa*, not a Latin form. ↵